

growing industry.

An estimated 275,000 jobs will be created in this sector over the next five years. Telecom, just like IT, is a growing industry because of the amount of innovation and growth it sees. It is an arm of technology that now plays a very fundamental part in our lives.

Reliance, Bharti Telecom, Tata Indicom, Hutch (Vodafone), MTNL and BPL are the major operators in India. Aircel has also stepped in as a major player.

There are many more, such as Unitech, Shyam and others, in the pipeline. Until recently, only the PSUs, BSNL and MTNL, were allowed to provide Basic Phone Service through copper wires in India. MTNL is operating in Delhi and Mumbai only and all other parts are covered by BSNL. However private operators have now entered the fray, although their focus is largely on the cellular business which is growing rapidly.

Career path and future prospects

People with a broad-level experience and understanding of the industry can also move into the software field. Once you understand the software or hardware side completely you can move into sales. Domain knowledge is a prerequisite to sell it. Hence, if you come from a sales background you cannot move into the software or hardware divisions.

The options for a fresh engineer are pretty open. The skills you possess determine the field that you choose. You could start from software for VAS, handsets and infrastructure and then switch between these mid-career.

Abhinav Goyal, a telecom software professional working for a telecom equipment manufacturer says that depending on the company employing them, people could be working for:

- **Independent Software Vendors (and services companies):** for example, Aricent
- **Hardware Vendors (and services companies):** for example, Flextronics
- **Telecom Equipment Manufacturers:** for example, Cisco
- **Network solution providers/integrators:** for example, GTL, IBM, Accenture (also an ISV)
- **Operators:** for example, Airtel, Vodafone
- **Network Operations and Management Companies:** for example, GTL, IBM

Future prospects

The career tracks are conventional and have a steady growth path. Besides the telecom companies, there are many research labs setting up in India which will require PhDs and MAs with hands-on knowledge of telecom. If you are interested in working on the next big thing then this could be your path.

Perhaps building the next slick handset appeals to you. If this is the case, then there is scope in new product development for APAC Markets as all handset manufacturers, except for the iPhone and Blackberry, are rolling out handsets here.

Traditionally, you could expect the following growth path in software or hardware roles:

Software/HW Engineer -> Senior software/HW engineer -> Assistant manager Software/HW -> Manager Software/HW